



Berthe Morisot, The Cradle (1872)

PSYCHOSOCIAL RESEARCH ROUNDS

Connected beginnings: How adult attachment style shapes perinatal mental health and early parental functioning

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Session chaired by Vincent Paquin, MD

January 14, 2027

2:00 PM – 2:30 PM (ET)

Amphitheatre (ICFP), 4333 Côte-St-Catherine Rd., Montreal QC H3T 1E4

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Learning objectives

- Describe how adult attachment styles are associated with vulnerability to perinatal mood and anxiety disorders (PMADs) across the perinatal period.
- Explain how insecure adult attachment and PMAD symptoms may contribute to early parenting outcomes, including parental functioning, self-efficacy, caregiving sensitivity, and parent-infant bonding.
- Reflect on the implications of adult attachment and PMAD symptoms for supporting parent-infant relationships and informing attachment-focused prevention and intervention strategies.

Abstract

Perinatal mood and anxiety disorders (PMADs) affect nearly one in four Canadian mothers and birthing parents and can negatively impact early parental functioning and the developing parent-infant relationship. Emerging evidence suggests that applying attachment theory to the perinatal context might help explain the risk for developing PMADS and the resulting consequences of impaired parental functioning and parent-infant bonding. Nevertheless, this has not been tested as a full mechanistic pathway in a multi-cohort framework, including both clinical and community-based samples.

In this talk, I will present findings from a CIHR-funded multicohort study examining the mechanistic links between adult attachment style, PMADs, and early parental functioning using two community-based and one clinical cohort (total N $\approx$ 3,884).

The presentation will highlight the potential value of attachment-informed approaches for understanding perinatal risk, supporting early parent-infant relationships, and informing future screening and intervention efforts.

About

Adrianne Tan is a Master of Science student in Mental Health at McGill University, supervised by Dr. Eszter Szekely. Her research interests and experience center on youth mental health and wellbeing, child development, family dynamics, and early-life interventions. Adrianne's work is supported by the CIHR CGS-M and the FRQS Master's awards.

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